

Memorandum

To: Dr. Ernest Gibson, Dr. Derek Ross, Dr. Susan Youngblood

From: Jolisa Brewster

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Subject: Website Development Analysis

Keywords: sitemaps, user experience, wireframes, web design.

Purpose

This analysis highlights the theoretical and design methods applied in Dr. Stewart Whittemore's web development graduate course to design and develop a functional website. The development process involving applying key principles of web design, usability, and information architecture to ensure an effective user experience. The primary purpose of this website is to showcase my portfolio work in a professional and accessible format.

Audience and Context

The intended audience for the website consists of potential employers and graduate committee members. As technology has evolved, technical communicators have increasingly moved beyond traditional printed manuals and documents to create digital content that can be accessed quickly and efficiently through web browsers and mobile devices. This website was designed to present professional content clearly, efficiently and a positive user experience for its intended audience.

Theory and Application

Wireframes

Wireframes can be understood as low fidelity visual frameworks that define the structure and functionality of a webpage (Hamm, 2024) before detailed design elements are applied. In development of my portfolio website, wire framing was using as a part of my planning stage. These early sketches made it easier to visualize the structure of the page and consider how users would move through the

site. Place holder elements were used to represent headings, images, and text blocks, supporting a focus on usability and information flow. In applying this approach to the website development, wireframes helped me evaluate different layout options and improve decision- making around menu structure and page organizations. Drawing on examples from existing websites further informed this process, highlighting effective design ideas. The main goal was to create a simple, and professional website that is easy to navigate and allows visitors to quickly navigate and understand the information presented clearly.

Site Maps

Sitemaps are visualization tools that are used predominantly for planning purposes, (Tankala, 2023) and helping designers organise website structure before development begins. A well-structured site map ensures that information is grouped logically and that users can easily locate the content they need. In the development of my portfolio website, a sketch sitemap was used to visualize the content for the website into clear sections such as “Work”, “About Me” and “Contact”. Each section directs users to the relevant location on the site, supporting efficient navigation and coherent user experience.

Conclusion

These are some of the methods I took into consideration to help to reduce confusion, improve usability, and support the overall goal of using my website- helping users understand and navigate the site successfully. By applying clear structural planning, and consistent layout choices, I aimed to create a user-friendly experience. Each design decision was made to ensure that information is easy to locate and logically organised.

References

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